

it beautiful legend and the believers who hold it "Gospel truth." My own vote between these alternative positions would depend on a series of considerations, critical and theological, which have nothing to do with Zoroastrianism. All I am concerned to prove here is that the narrative might have been composed by a Magus for the accuracy with which it portrays Magian ideas.¹ It might be Magian fiction, of course, like the original of *T'obit* discussed in Lecture VII. But since the author was confessedly a Jew, the correct colour of his "fiction" is at least interesting.²

¹ From Dr Casartelli's paper I should add his remarks on the appropriateness of "frankincense and myrrh." "The use of fragrant woods and vegetable perfumes has always been a characteristic of the Zoroastrian religious cult": he refers to *Vd* 8² and 7⁹, where *vohu.gaona* "is apparently frankincense."

² I have not repeated in this chapter all the points about the Fravashis which are mentioned in other Lectures: the Index *s.v.* will enable the reader to collect them. The most important is the reference of King Antiochus to his Fravashi as an *avatar* (ἐπιφανής): see p. 108.

LECTURE IX

ZARATHUSHTRA AND ISRAEL

From the rising of the sun even unto the going down of the same my name is great among the Gentiles; and in every place incense is offered unto my name, and a pure offering; for my name is great among the Gentiles, saith Yahweh of Hosts.¹

Malachi i. 11.

THE main purpose of this concluding Lecture is not that which will appear at first sight from its title. An active discussion has been going on for a generation as to the reality and extent of influences passing from one to the other of the two greatest religions of Western Asia. I naturally cannot decline all reference to this controversy, and hope to have something to say about it before I have done. But before suggesting any answer to the question whether Zarathushtra influenced Israel, or Israel Zarathushtra, I want to take a summary view of Parsism in the light of another religion, using the comparative method as a help to bring out the essential character of the religion which I am trying to interpret. The moral of the comparison may be reserved for the

¹ See E. Meyer, *Gesch. d. Alt.*, iii. 171, on the implication from the Jewish prophet's words that the everywhere worshipped God of heaven and Ruler of the world was in his mind identified with Yahweh.

present : points of similarity and of difference between the two religions, in spheres of thought which concern the deepest essentials, will sufficiently occupy our attention ; and in most of these points independence is so obvious that we shall not be troubled with suspicions of borrowing. Coincidences will be the independent agreement of deep thinkers upon the same great problems, and their independence will enhance their suggestiveness. Our line will resemble that of Professor Harnack in a striking paper in the *Hibbert Journal* for October 1911, in which he sketched the religion of Porphyry, showing in how many points it unconsciously resembled the faith which the philosopher in his controversial work so bitterly attacked. And at the other end of the scale of human thought we shall find an apt parallel in the coincidences which perpetually meet us as we study primitive religions in *The Golden Bough*. The human mind has an ultimate identity of constitution on many sides wherever we find it ; and when its powers are brought to bear upon identical material the results tend to approximate.

I must not further anticipate the promised moral, but proceed to sum up afresh some of the leading characteristics of Early Zoroastrianism in terms of a comparison with ideas found in the religion of Israel. By the religion of Israel I mean of course the religion in its full and complete development, including the crown of the whole system in the teaching of Jesus, and the apostolic interpretation of it. Indeed, as a main part of my subject is concerned with the phenomena of religious syncretism, it is reasonable to expect helpful illustration even from

the syncretisms of later Christianity, which cast its net into many waters and gathered of many kinds, both bad and good.

I cannot state my text better than by quoting a page from Prof. Bousset's well-known work on Judaism in New Testament times.¹ The author is a leader among those who believe in a definite and powerful influence exerted upon Judaism and early Christianity by Parsi thought. I shall have to argue against this view, except to a very limited extent, but the passage will serve none the worse as a statement of the common features of the religions, however explained :

In the Persian religion the later Judaism came in contact with a powerful and influential faith, predominant in one part of the world and strongly impressing even the Greeks, which at least in its purer form was almost of equal rank with itself. In no other religion outside Judaism was there so pronounced and triumphant a movement of belief towards monotheism—if we make allowance for the strong tendency to dualism. Ahura Mazdah is, among all the deities of the world that surrounded Judaism, distinctively of a type which can most easily be compared with that of Yahweh. We have here also a strong spiritualising, transcendental bent, a deep-seated union of religion with earnest ethical thought. And in details how many resemblances and agreements are found! Here, as there, the thought of the hereafter and the judgement is central, and the doctrine of individual rewards and punishments is complementary to apocalyptic, the elaborated doctrine of the future of the world. In both religions there is a tendency towards dualism: the Kingdom of God, of Ahura Mazdah, stands in contrast with that of the devil, of Angra Mainyu. In both we find remarkable coincidences in

¹ *Die Religion des Judentums in neutestamentlichen Zeitalter*, ed.² (1906), p. 549.

speculations concerning God and divine beings (*Hypostases*¹ = Amesha Spenta); in both, sacrifice and worship (*Kult*) recedes before ritual and ceremonial, and we may characterise both as religions of observance (of the Law). In both great stress is laid on the care of the poor. Just as the order of Scribes arose in Judaism over against the priesthood, the Magi among the Persians gained increasingly the character of theologians, commentators, and custodians of an ancient scripture tradition. Just as a canon of Scripture was formed in later Judaism, Parsism appears in the same period to have possessed a like collection. True, in all this there need not be any dependence: it may all be parallel development. But the coincidence in so many points is extremely remarkable, and compels us to examine it more closely. For we are concerned here with contacts and perhaps with dependence in the very centre of things.

One more quotation may be in place before I proceed to elaborate the parallel. Prof. Söderblom, at the beginning of his important work, *Les Fravashis*, quotes a late Parsi creed according to the translation of Darmesteter. It runs thus:

I have no doubt as to the truth of the good religion of the worshippers of Mazda, the coming of the Resurrection and the future life, the passing of the Cinvat Bridge, the account made during the Three Nights [after death] of merits and reward, of faults and punishment, the truth of heaven and hell, the annihilation of Ahriman and the demons, the final victory of God the Spirit of Good, and the destruction of the spirit of evil and the demons, the brood of darkness.

¹ A definition of these *hypostases* may be appended from Prof. Bertholet's continuation of Stade, *Bibl. Theol. des A. T.*, II. 394: they are "nicht ganz so anschaulich konkrete, volkstümliche Gestalten wie die Engel, aber auch nicht reine abstrakte Gedankengebilde; die naive Philosophie denkt sie sich in gewisser Weise persönlich" (W. Luekens, *Die Schriften des N. T.*, II. 335).

This *credo* is removed by its date from the Early Zoroastrianism to which we are limited, but it is completely in the spirit of the oldest period. We cannot read it without recognising how little material change must be made to enable devout Christians to use it heartily. We should have to add to it, and add what is of primary importance, but there is nothing to take away. It is well to realise this at the outset, that we may the better appreciate our problem.

The comparison in detail may begin with the idea of God. That the divine name "Wise Lord" is closely akin to Biblical conceptions needs no proof. But it is interesting to observe that the Old Testament conception of "wisdom" as a strictly practical and ethical attribute answers well to Zarathushtra's view, in which there is no room for merely speculative or theoretical knowledge. The omniscience of the Creator is a point kept in great prominence by Zarathushtra, who would have found nothing to question in such an exposition as the twenty-eighth chapter of *Job*. The doctrine grew in explicitness in later times, when this attribute of Deity was so conspicuous that ignorance and blindness had to be primary features of the evil spirit who was the mechanical antithesis of the Good in all his functions. Another parallel development may be seen in the conception of the "wisdom" that God gives to men. In the Hebrew scriptures it is the "fear of Yahweh," the knowledge how to live in conformity to the will of God. In the book of *Proverbs* Wisdom is personified in a way that reminds us strongly of Aramaiti, whom Plutarch represented as *Σοφία*. The